12–18 MONTH STRATEGIC PLAN

Future-Proofing a DBA Career

From Lead DBA to Database Reliability & Platform Engineer — with an AI edge

Profile	Lead DBA (Technical) — 12+ years; DB2, PostgreSQL, MySQL/MariaDB, MongoDB; Kubernetes, Percona Operator, ArgoCD
Base	Hyderabad / Vijayawada, India (GCC + remote market)
Target role	Database Reliability Engineer (DBRE) / Database Platform Engineer
Horizon	18 months, organised in five phases with quarterly checkpoints

The thesis in one line: the **maintenance** DBA is being automated away; the **engineering** DBA — who operates databases as code, owns reliability, and brings AI into operations — is scarce and well paid. You are already standing on the right side of that line. This plan turns 12 years of experience into a differentiated, hard-to-hire profile rather than resetting the clock.

Prepared June 2026 • Indicative timeline — adapt to your pace and on-the-job opportunities

1 — Why this plan, and why now

At 12 years, the next move compounds the most. The goal of this roadmap is not to chase a trend but to reposition the deep expertise you already have onto the part of the market that AI *augments* rather than *replaces*.

The split inside the DBA role

Fading (automatable)	Growing (engineering & judgment)
Routine backups & restores Patching & minor upgrades Basic monitoring & alerting Routine index / query tuning Manual provisioning	HA / failover & replication architecture Databases-as-code (IaC) & GitOps Reliability: SLOs, capacity, cost Data governance, security & compliance AI-augmented automation & tooling

Industry estimates put up to ~45% of database-related *tasks* on a path to automation by 2030 — almost entirely from the left column. The right column is where senior judgment lives, and it is exactly the work you already do: Percona Operator on Kubernetes, ArgoCD, your DB2 DDL automation tooling, and disciplined runbooks. This plan deepens the right column and makes it legible to the market.

The market direction (India, 2026)

- **Platform engineering, SRE and cloud/data roles** sit at the top of India's hiring-difficulty curve — high demand, scarce talent, salary inflation.
- **GCCs (Global Capability Centers)** in Hyderabad are shifting from support to product/engineering hubs and hiring exactly these niche profiles.
- **DBRE / Database Platform Engineer** postings (Okta, Autodesk, GitLab, Salesforce) read like your résumé: PostgreSQL/MySQL at scale + Terraform/Ansible + CI/CD + Kubernetes + reliability.
- **Remote senior roles** pay materially more than domestic-only roles — relevant if you want to stay near Vijayawada while earning Hyderabad-or-better.

2 — The target role you are aiming at

Not a generic DevOps engineer (crowded entry/mid market — a downgrade for a 12-year specialist). **Instead**, the convergence role that compounds your experience:

DATABASE RELIABILITY ENGINEER (DBRE) / DATABASE PLATFORM ENGINEER

A DBRE blends database engineering, software/automation, and SRE practice — operating databases as code, owning their reliability, performance, security and cost, and acting as a peer to SRE and platform teams. It sits precisely at the intersection of what you know (databases) and what you want to learn (DevOps, Terraform, Kubernetes, AI tooling).

What you already have vs. what to add

Already strong	Gaps to close in 18 months
PostgreSQL internals, replication, pgBackRest, pg_rewind, WAL MySQL/MariaDB & DB2 administration MongoDB administration Kubernetes + Percona Operator, ArgoCD Python/Bash automation & CLI tooling Production runbook & documentation discipline	Terraform (IaC) to expert; Ansible One cloud platform deep (AWS or GCP) + managed DBs CI/CD: Git workflows, Jenkins/GitHub Actions, Maven, SonarQube, Trivy SRE practice: SLO/SLI, error budgets, capacity & cost Observability stack (Prometheus/Grafana) to depth AI-augmented ops tooling + a public portfolio Legible proof: CKA + cloud cert

3 — The 18-month roadmap (five phases)

Each phase builds on the last. Hours are a guide for a working professional — roughly 6–8 focused hours/week. Wherever possible, do the learning **on the job**: convert real tasks at SS&C into IaC, runbooks and tooling.

PHASE 0	**Month 0** · Baseline & positioning

- Audit your current stack against the DBRE job descriptions; list 5 concrete gaps.
- Create a clean GitHub profile; pick a portfolio theme (database platform automation).
- Set up a learning log; choose AWS *or* GCP as your primary cloud (AWS recommended for DB breadth).
- Define your one-line positioning: 'DBRE who operates Postgres/MySQL at scale as code, with AI-assisted ops.'

PHASE 1	**Months 1–4** · Deepen the data foundation + first IaC

- PostgreSQL/MySQL/Mongo depth: HA topologies, failover testing, capacity & cost modelling (your short-term goal).
- Git to fluency: branching, PRs, code review, trunk-based workflow.
- Terraform fundamentals → provision a real database stack (VM or managed) entirely from code.
- Observability: stand up Prometheus + Grafana with meaningful DB dashboards and alerts.
- Portfolio Project #1 ships (see §5).

PHASE 2	**Months 5–9** · Platform & DevOps layer (your long-term goal)

- Docker to depth; Kubernetes beyond Percona — Helm, operators, stateful workloads, storage classes.
- CI/CD pipeline: Jenkins *or* GitHub Actions + Maven/build tool + SonarQube + Trivy scanning.
- GitOps with ArgoCD for database platform manifests (extend what you already use).
- Ansible for configuration management of DB fleets.
- Begin **CKA** preparation. Portfolio Projects #2 and #3 ship.

PHASE 3	**Months 10–14** · AI-augmented tooling + certify

- Sit and pass **CKA**; start one cloud cert (AWS SAA or Database Specialty).
- SRE practice: define SLO/SLI/error budgets for a database service; write the reliability runbook.
- Build AI-assisted ops tools (anomaly triage, runbook copilot, self-service provisioning agent) — your AI edge.
- Publish 1–2 technical write-ups; start sharing work publicly.
- Portfolio Project #4 (AI-augmented) ships.

PHASE 4	**Months 15–18** · Consolidate, prove, reposition

- Finish cloud cert; polish the portfolio into a coherent 'database platform' story.
- Refactor résumé and LinkedIn around DBRE / Platform Engineer outcomes (reliability, cost, automation).
- Targeted outreach to Hyderabad GCCs and remote-first product companies.
- Optional: launch a small side output (content / tool / course) — see §8.
- Portfolio Projects #5–#6 ship; capstone end-to-end demo recorded.

4 — Certification & proof timeline

Certifications make existing depth *legible* to recruiters and GCC screening. For you, projects matter more than certs — but a couple of well-chosen credentials remove friction.

Window	Credential	Why it matters for you
Months 5–11	**CKA — Certified Kubernetes Administrator**	Highest-weight cert for the platform side; validates the K8s work you already do.
Months 11–16	**AWS Solutions Architect Associate (or GCP ACE)**	Cloud is where managed databases live; signals cloud fluency to GCCs.
Months 14–18	**AWS Database Specialty (optional)**	Directly badges your core strength on the dominant cloud platform.
Ongoing	**HashiCorp Terraform Associate (optional)**	Cheap, fast credential that proves IaC competence.

5 — Portfolio projects (your real proof)

A public GitHub of database-platform tooling is worth more than any certificate. Six projects, each shippable and résumé-worthy, sequenced with the phases. Sanitise anything from work before publishing.

#	Project	Skills proven	Phase
1	**Terraform module that provisions a HA PostgreSQL cluster (primary + standby) with backups wired to pgBackRest**	Terraform, Postgres HA, IaC	1
2	**GitOps repo: database platform on Kubernetes via Percona Operator + ArgoCD, fully declarative**	K8s, ArgoCD, GitOps	2
3	**CI/CD pipeline for DB schema/DDL changes with linting, SonarQube, Trivy scan and gated promotion**	Jenkins/Actions, SonarQube, Trivy	2
4	**AI ops copilot: an agent that triages alerts / drafts runbook steps from logs (built with Claude API)**	Python, LLM/agent, observability	3
5	**SLO + observability kit: Prometheus rules, Grafana dashboards and error-budget reporting for a DB service**	SRE, Prometheus/Grafana	4
6	**Self-service DB provisioning tool (CLI/portal) with safety tiers and audit logging — productised from your DB2 tool**	Platform eng, automation, UX	4

6 — The AI edge (run this in parallel)

Do not try to become an ML engineer — that is a different, crowded career. Your edge is being the person who **brings AI into database and platform operations**, building tools that almost nobody at the DBRE + AI intersection can build. You already prototype tools with Claude; make it deliberate and public.

- **Foundations:** how LLMs and APIs work, prompting, structured output, retrieval (RAG), and agent/tool-use patterns — enough to build, not to research.
- **Applied ops tooling:** alert triage, log summarisation, runbook copilots, query/plan explainers, natural-language DB diagnostics.
- **Agentic automation:** safe, guard-railed agents for provisioning and routine ops with human approval on side-effects.
- **MLOps-adjacent skills (light):** understand how data platforms feed AI/ML so you can speak to data-infra-for-AI work that GCCs are funding.
- **Publish:** a GitHub project + a short write-up beats a course certificate for this skill.

7 — Geography & job-market strategy

Hyderabad	Vijayawada	Remote / Global
Major GCC hub; product & platform/SRE/DBRE roles concentrate here. Your primary on-site market.	Thin tech-depth market. Best treated as a home base supported by remote work, not a job market for this role.	DBRE/platform skills travel well. Remote senior roles pay materially more — lets you stay near family while earning more.

Play: anchor your search to Hyderabad GCCs/product companies and remote-first employers. Use the portfolio and CKA to clear screening; lead with reliability, automation and cost outcomes, not task lists.

8 — Safeguarding your future & diversifying

Three layers, in order of return.

Layer 1 — Career capital (highest ROI)

Your skills are your strongest asset by a wide margin. The DBRE + AI repositioning above *is* the primary safeguard — it keeps you on the side of the market AI augments. No investment portfolio will outperform staying scarce and in demand.

Layer 2 — A side output that compounds your day job

You already build tools and write strong technical documentation. The lowest-conflict, highest-synergy side income is one that feeds your main career instead of competing with it:

- Paid technical content / a focused course on PostgreSQL HA or Kubernetes database operations.
- A small productised tool or template pack in the database/DevOps space.
- Selective freelance/consulting on Postgres reliability and K8s database platforms.
- Each of these also builds the public portfolio that makes you more hireable — double benefit.

Layer 3 — Financial diversification (kept boring)

General structure many professionals use — emergency fund first (6–12 months of expenses), then diversified long-term investing (broad index funds / SIPs rather than single-stock or speculative bets), and only after that any illiquid or business venture. Avoid funding a hands-on business that drains time from your core moat unless you have a genuine edge in it.

Note: I am not a licensed financial advisor and this is general framing, not personalised investment advice. For decisions involving your specific finances, a fee-only financial planner is worth a one-time consultation given a lead-DBA income.

9 — Quarterly checkpoints (track against these)

By month	You should be able to point to...
Month 3	Primary cloud chosen; Git fluent; Terraform basics done; Project #1 live on GitHub.
Month 6	K8s/Docker depth; a working CI/CD pipeline; CKA prep underway; Projects #2–#3 live.
Month 9	GitOps + Ansible in the portfolio; observability stack built; CKA scheduled.
Month 12	CKA passed; first AI ops tool published; SLOs defined for a service; cloud cert started.
Month 15	Cloud cert passed; résumé/LinkedIn repositioned; active outreach to GCCs/remote roles.
Month 18	6 projects + capstone demo; interviewing (or promoted internally) as DBRE/Platform Engineer.

Bottom line: your profession isn't ending — the *maintenance* version is fading while the *engineering* version is scarce and well paid, and you already stand in the right spot. Fuse DBA + DevOps into DBRE / Platform Engineering, add a deliberate AI-tooling track, certify what you already know, build the portfolio, and anchor to Hyderabad GCCs or remote roles. That single repositioning safeguards the career more than any side bet.